

THE FIRST USER STORY CHECKLIST

The path from a vague request to a story a developer and tester could both build from.

BEFORE YOU WRITE "AS A..."

A user story is not something you invent.

It is something you uncover. The three-line story is the headline — the useful requirement lives underneath it.

1 FIND THE PROBLEM

A button is a solution. Ask what problem it solves first.

2 FIND THE USER

"Customers" is too broad. Which customers, specifically?

3 FIND THE OUTCOME

What are they actually trying to achieve?

4 WRITE THE FIRST DRAFT

As a... I want... So that... A headline, not the requirement.

5 ADD BUSINESS RULES

What wasn't in the request, but governs it anyway?

6 WRITE TESTABLE AC

Given / When / Then — specific enough for QA to test.

7 NAME THE EXCEPTIONS

What happens when the normal flow fails?

8 SURFACE DATA & SCOPE

What's needed, who's involved, what's deliberately excluded?

MY FIRST USER STORY CHECKLIST

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|--|---|
| ☐ I understand the actual problem | ☐ I know who the user is |
| ☐ I understand the outcome they need | ☐ The story describes value, not just a solution |
| ☐ Important business rules are captured | ☐ Acceptance criteria are testable |
| ☐ Important exceptions are considered | ☐ Data expectations are understood |
| ☐ Dependencies are visible | ☐ Out-of-scope items are clear |
| ☐ Open questions are visible | ☐ Someone can understand it without me in the room |

REMEMBER

A user story is not something you invent. It is something you uncover.

Writing "As a... I want... So that..." takes twenty seconds. Everything before it is the actual work.